these distinctions: the Geneva Conventions forbid an occupying power from settling its civilian population in occupied territory, regardless of the circumstances, and thus the United Nations and much of the world view all settlements as illegitimate.)

Amona came under scrutiny in 2014, when a police investigation revealed that the entire outpost was built on privately-owned land. The Supreme Court, unsurprisingly, soon ordered the outpost to be evacuated, and gave the state two years to carry out its ruling. Asher Grunis, then the chief justice, tried to head off any attempt to dodge the order. “Because the structures were built on private lands, it is impossible to authorize them, even retroactively,” he wrote in his ruling.

Netanyahu, busy with elections and always loathe to anger the right, dawdled for eighteen months. In the summer of 2016, his government offered to relocate the settlers, following the example of Migron. They would receive new homes nearby, on the outskirts of Ofra, an approved settlement. But they refused. Ayelet Shaked, the justice minister, then drafted a bill to legalize Amona, in exchange for a compensation payment to the Palestinian owners of the land. Her effort was quickly stymied by the attorney general, who advised the cabinet that the bill was probably unconstitutional.

It is worth pausing for a moment to emphasize how exceptional this behavior is. The settlers in Amona (and those in other outposts) were breaking the law—not just international law, but Israeli law. And their own government bent over backwards to retroactively accommodate their illegal behavior. It’s an imperfect comparison, but imagine a businessman who built a factory in Yellowstone, then demanded compensation when the government showed up to bulldoze it. And then go a step further: imagine that a powerful faction within Congress drew up a bill to cede that chunk of the park to the factory owner. Avigdor Lieberman, the right-wing defense minister and a settler himself, emerged as one of the few voices of caution. “There is a judgment of the Supreme Court and we shall honor it,” he said on 1 September, at an event in an Israeli settlement marking the first day of school. But the prime minister, fearful of losing support to Bennett’s party, pressed forward with his search for a “solution”. After the High Holidays, like a college student who fell behind on a term paper, he asked the court for a seven-month extension. The settlers ramped up the pressure, holding